"Why try? I can never succeed."

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Where it often comes from

Repeated failure at school, work, or tasks teaches that effort leads nowhere. Learned helplessness protects us from disappointment but also from growth.

What Scripture teaches

"I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength." "The LORD is my strength and my song, and He has become my salvation." "Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men" (Colossians 3:23). Success is not only measured by grades or speed. Each honest effort, each step forward, matters to God. Choose small, achievable goals and celebrate them.

> *"I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength"* (Philippians 4:13).

Also see

> "The LORD is my strength and my song, and He has become my salvation" (Psalm 118:14).
>
> "Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men" (Colossians 3:23).
>
> "Let us not grow weary in well-doing, for in due time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up" (Galatians 6:9).
>
> "Anxiety weighs down the heart of a man, but a good word cheers it up" (Proverbs 12:25).

Common self-statements

- Nothing I do works.
- Trying only leads to failure.
- I give up.
- Others succeed, not me.
- I was not made for this.
- It is safer not to try.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I either succeed fully or fail.
- Fortune telling: Predicting failure.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling defeated and concluding it is pointless.
- Overgeneralizing: Calling myself a failure.

Challenging questions

- When have I succeeded, even in something small?
- What helped then?
- What would a tiny, achievable goal look like?
- Who could help me?
- What does Scripture say about strength?
- How can I define success differently?

Truth summary

> Success includes honest effort and small steps. With Christ's strength and the right help, I can try again and grow, and God honors faithfulness.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Hopeless
- Laziness
- Faith
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Strength

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Why try? I can never succeed"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Why try? I can never succeed." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When have I succeeded, even in something small?
- ☐ What helped then?
- ☐ What would a tiny, achievable goal look like?
- ☐ Who could help me?
- ☐ What does Scripture say about strength?
- ☐ How can I define success differently?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can do all things through Christ.
- ☐ The Lord is my strength.
- ☐ I work for the Lord.
- ☐ Small steps count.
- ☐ I will not grow weary.
- ☐ Encouragement helps.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Philippians 4:13
  "I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength."
- ☐ Psalm 118:14
  "The LORD is my strength and my song, and He has become my salvation."
- ☐ Colossians 3:23
  "Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Small wins: Each week, note one small win.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Philippians 4:13 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Hopeless" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] List past wins. Write times you succeeded.
- [ ] Set a tiny goal. Make it achievable.
- [ ] Celebrate. Tell someone about the win.
- [ ] Get help. Ask a tutor, coach, or friend.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Why try? I can never succeed": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Small wins
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Why try? I can never succeed.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I am tired of failing. Give me strength for small steps, patient helpers, and joy in honest effort. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.